Album Photos application guide (English)

Version of 01/11/2026. One window gathers every step of the photo book and of the photo-letters poster. Each button does exactly what the `.bat` file of the same name does; the `.bat` files still work.

Safety rule: the application only **reads** your photos. It never changes, moves or deletes anything on the backup drive. Everything it creates goes into the work folder, for example `C:\AlbumsFamille`.

Language: the 🌐 **EN / FR** button at the top right switches the application language. The language of the book itself is set in Settings > Book > "Language of the book and letters poster" (`fr` or `en`). Detailed log messages stay in French.

1. Install the application (once)

Step	What to do
1. Python	If Python is not installed yet: https://www.python.org/downloads/. On the first screen tick **"Add python.exe to PATH"**, then restart the PC.
2. The tool	Unzip the zip you received (e.g. in Documents). The tool's author uses their Git copy `%USERPROFILE%\AlbumPhotos\outils\albums-famille`.
3. Install	In that folder, double-click **`Installer_application.bat`**. It installs the libraries (a few minutes the first time), creates the **Album Photos** icon on the Desktop and in the Start menu, then opens the application.
4. Afterwards	Simply open **Album Photos** from the Desktop.

Check the tool (automatic tests)

The 🔧 **Maintenance** > **Check the tool (tests)** button (or `9_tests_automatiques.bat`) runs 39 tests in 1 to 3 minutes on a small disk of **synthetic photos** created in a temporary folder: your photos, settings and books are not used. They cover analysis, selection, previews, final book with PowerPoint, letters poster, browser screens (security token), suggestions, translation, settings (multi-line letter, safe writing) and above all that **original photos are never modified**. At the end, "OK" and "Tous les tests sont passés" appear in green; otherwise send `journal.txt` to Claude.

2. The screen

Area	Role
Top bar	Name of the book's person, folders in use, version. On the right: running step, activity bar, ■ **Stop the step** button, 🌐 **EN / FR** button.
Left column	The step buttons, in order (1 to 5; setup and updates are in 🔧 **Maintenance**): **blue ▶ buttons**; **the recommended one is green**. While a step runs, the others are greyed out. Below, the white "Open" buttons open the folders.
Log tab	What the step is doing, live. The green line at the top gives the recommended next step. Errors are in red.
Settings tab	All settings, on three pages: Photos and people, Book, Letters poster. Each setting is in a white box: a bold title, the field to fill in (blue border while typing, ▼ arrow for a list) and grey help text. Green ✔ **Save the settings** button at the top (saving is also automatic before each step).
Help tab	This guide.

3. Making the book step by step

No.	Button	What happens
0	**Settings** tab	Fill in at least: photo folder ("Browse..."), work folder, person of the book, close relatives, date of birth, "home" countries (FR,PH).
1	🔧 **Maintenance** > **Install / repair**	Checks the libraries and creates one reference photo folder per person.
—	**Reference photos** (Open)	Put 3 to 10 sharp photos of each person's face in their folder, at different ages, baby included.
2	**Analyse the drive**	Reads all photos (dates, places, faces, sharpness). Can be stopped and restarted: work already done is kept. Several hours the first time.
3	**Prepare the selection**	Suggests the book photos, grouped into memories.
3a	**Choose the photos**	The browser opens: one click keeps / removes a photo, 🔍 enlarges it. Filter buttons: ★ **Special**, ★ **Cover**, ★ **Full page**, ✉ **Letters**, ◆ **Master**, **Set aside**, with their counts. Finish with **Terminer** on the page.
3b	**Reduce the selection** *(optional)*	Kept photos only, with the best candidates for removal flagged.
3c	**Suggest improvements** *(optional)*	A screen opens: each suggestion (replace, add, remove) with its photos; **one click accepts or refuses it**, "Accept all" / "Refuse all", then **"Apply the choices"** updates the selection (backup copy made). No more Excel. "Review the suggestions" reopens this screen without recomputing.

No.	Button	What happens
4	**Style previews**	A window lets you **tick the styles to make or redo**; unticked previews stay as they are. One preview PDF per style in the book folder.
—	Settings > Book	Choose the **style**; if you wish, the number of pages, organisation, language, footer, end text, dedication.
5	**Final book**	The book + the printer folder: PDF, photos numbered in order, Excel instructions, assembly plan.
5b	**Book + editable PowerPoint** *(optional)*	Same, plus a `.pptx` file to retouch a page by hand.

Book options (Settings > Book)

Setting	Example	Effect
Language of the book	`en`	Titles, dates, ages, countries, bubbles and fixed pages in English. Hand-typed captions and titles stay as typed.
Footer	`Laura · 2012-2024`	Small text at the bottom of the pages, on the outer side.
Pages with the footer	`photos-uniques`	`toutes` = every page after the first; `photos-uniques` = only pages with a single photo.
Text at the end of the album	a multi-paragraph letter	Large text box in the application, saved in `texte_fin.txt`. Line breaks and paragraphs are kept, the size adapts so everything fits (never cut), a short first line ("My darling,") becomes a heading. A ❤️ becomes a drawn heart.
Symbol above the end text	`coeurs`	coeurs, coeur, fleur, ornement, colombe, etoiles or aucun: drawn in the application; click a drawing to choose it.
Caption box colour (comic styles)	`vert`	yellow (default), blue, dark blue, green, pink, orange, red, purple... or `#RRGGBB`.

Comic styles: bubbles and caption boxes

The bubble ("Happy birthday!") and the caption box go where there is no face, with a smaller font if needed (down to 9 pt). If no free spot exists, there is no bubble. If the photo is reduced (quality), the caption box goes in the free space next to it.

Checks shown in the previews only

- orange label: photo reduced to stay sharp when printed;
- red label: a face is already cut off in the original photo (no crop can fix it: replace the photo if possible). Both are listed on the last page of the preview.

Improving face recognition

Problem	What to do
Photos kept **without the person**	**Check the recognition** button: faces given to the person, **least sure first**. **× Not Laura** forbids it for good, **✓ It's Laura** adds a reference at that exact age. Then run **Prepare the selection** again.
A photo **without the person** in the choice screen	Hover it and click **× Not Laura** (or key **N** when enlarged): removed from the book **and** never suggested again. Each refusal also teaches the tool to reject look-alike faces.
Start from scratch	**Check the recognition** screen > **Erase all my corrections**, then **Prepare the selection** (answer "o": the selection is rebuilt entirely).
Missed photos	Same screen, "Maybe Laura" list: one ✓ click.
Many errors	Settings > "Face likeness requirement": 0.45 or 0.50.
Reference photos	10 to 20 per person, **one per period**, large sharp frontal face, **alone or clearly in front**. Photos with several same-size faces, or unlike the others, are discarded automatically (see the log).

Making another person's book (Bo, Hugo...)

The drive analysis is done once for the whole family. It detects faces and computes their fingerprints, but does not yet know who is who. Recognising the book's person happens at "Prepare the selection", by comparing faces with the reference photos.

For a new book	To do
1	Settings > "Person of the book": the new name (and close relatives)
2	**Reference photos**: 3 to 10 sharp photos of their face in `famille\<Name>`
3	**Prepare the selection**, then the usual steps
×	**No need to rerun "Analyse the drive"**: only if you add photos to the drive (only new ones are analysed). The application reminds you if you click it.

Each person has their own `livre_<Name>` folder: books never mix.

4. The photo-letters poster

No.	Where	What to do
1	Settings > Letters poster	Word, texts above and below, format, designs, colours.
2	**Choose the letter photos**	The browser opens: click one photo per letter (placed by date). The book selection is not changed.
3	**Create the letters poster**	The designs as 300 dpi JPEG + PDF, plus `Comparaison_modeles.jpg`.
4	**Letter posters** (Open)	Choose the design for the printer.

Schematic preview: in Settings > Letters poster, the poster is drawn live next to the settings (format, background, font, outline, colours, one or two lines, texts; coloured letters stand for the photos). The "Designs to make" list just above sets both what is shown and what will be made: one design, or "all" (the 6 as thumbnails). In English, every drop-down list (colours, formats, styles, symbols...) and the photo selection screens in the browser are in English too; the settings file always keeps the same codes.

To put the poster on the first page of the book: Settings > Letters poster > "Put the poster in the photo book" = `premiere-page` (or `premiere-et-derniere`).

4b. The photo mosaic

A "master" photo (a portrait, for example) rebuilt from hundreds of small album photos: from afar you see the face, up close every memory.

No.	Where	What to do
1	**Choose the photos**	Enlarge a photo (🔍) then ◆ **Master**: it becomes the photo to rebuild (the book selection is unchanged). Or: Settings > Mosaic > "Master photo" > Browse... Without a choice: the cover.
2	Settings > Mosaic	Format **A4 to A0**, small photos across (60; 80 to 120 for A0), master blended on top (0.35), "kept" or "all" photos, or a **thumbnail photos folder** (Settings > Mosaic, optional; never changed). Empty = the album's selected photos; filled = the small photos come from that folder; "kept + folder" = both.
2b	**Mosaic preview** (or "↻ Refresh the	Quick render in a few seconds with the current settings, shown next to the settings: try formats, photo counts and blends before making the poster.

No.	Where	What to do
	preview" in Settings > Mosaic)	
3	**Create the mosaic**	`livre_<Name>\mosaique` : the large JPEG for the printer, a preview, a close-up detail and the list of photos used.

Advanced settings: face rendering (adaptive = more detail on eyes and mouth), small photos tint, line between photos, gap between identical photos, bleed (3 mm), and **text on the photo** ("|" = new line; position auto/top/bottom/centre/corners, font, colour, size, style shadow/outline/band). Printer files: maximum-quality JPEG with sRGB profile and a PDF at the exact size.

Quality: 300 dpi up to A2, 200 dpi for A1, 150 dpi for A0 (poster standard). At least 150 photos recommended.

5. Maintenance, updating and sharing

The 🔧 **Maintenance** button (top right) opens a window with **Install / repair** and **Check the tool (tests)** for everyone, and, **for the administrator only**, **Update the tool** (from GitHub) and **Make the zip to share** (a clean copy without your settings, data or GitHub link, in the work folder). Administrator mode is automatic on the author's Git copy, or with an empty `admin.txt` file next to the application. A shared copy has no GitHub button and cannot update itself.

Administrator: click **Update the tool**: the application downloads the latest version, then offers to restart. Your settings, selections and books are never touched. Libraries are reinstalled only when their list has changed (faster updates).

Note: after an update that changes how photos are framed, the first preview takes longer (every crop is redone). The next ones are fast again.

6. Troubleshooting

Problem	Solution
The icon does nothing	Double-click `Lancer_application.bat`. If Python is not found, reinstall it with "Add python.exe to PATH" ticked, then run `Installer_application.bat` again.
"Libraries to install"	🔧 **Maintenance** > **Install / repair**.

Problem	Solution
Photo folder not found	Plug in the backup drive; if its letter changed (D:, E:…), fix the path in Settings.
A step seems stuck	The bar moves as long as it works. For selection screens, finish with **Terminer** in the browser. Otherwise ■ **Stop the step**.
A red error	Click **journal.txt** (Open) and send that file to Claude.